

VIDEO GAME DESIGN - KEY CONCEPTS

Here is a list of the key concepts that you need to know to talk about video game design.

3D Model - An object in a game that uses polygons to create a 3-dimensional effect.

3D Model Frame - The wire frame, or 'skeleton' of a 3D model. The frame can be animated to make the model move.

Balance - The process of making game elements, challenges, and resources fair and enjoyable. An unbalanced game might be too difficult or too easy.

Core Fantasy - The central experience or role of the player in the game. For example, the player could be the hero of a kingdom, a survivor in a dangerous world, a builder who creates things, or a commander of a powerful army.

Difficulty Curve - The planned progression of challenge throughout a game. As players become better at the game and their characters become more powerful, the game needs to become more difficult to remain balanced (see 'balance').

Economy - The management and flow of resources, currencies, items, and rewards within the game. Game economy is not only money, but other resources, like magic powers, items, abilities, etc.

Emergent Gameplay - Unexpected situations or strategies that happen naturally from the interaction of game systems. Emergent gameplay makes the game world feel natural and real.

Feedback - Visual, audio, or tactile responses that communicate the results of a player's actions.

Game Loop - The core cycle of actions that players repeat throughout the game (for example, explore → fight → earn rewards → upgrade → and repeat). A game can have multiple game loops.

Gameplay - The set of actions and interactions that players perform while engaging with a game. Gameplay is determined by 'game mechanics', 'user interface', and the 'game loop'.

Immersion - The feeling of being inside the game's world, story, or systems. Immersion makes the player feel like they are living in the world of the game.

Level Design - The creation of environments, or "levels", in the game. Gameplay elements like challenges and progression should be built into the environment of the game.

Game Mechanics - The rules and systems that define how the game operates and how players can interact with it. Players often interact with game mechanics through the 'user interface'.

Narrative - The story, lore, and storytelling methods used to provide context and meaning to gameplay.

Onboarding - The process of teaching new players the rules, controls, and objectives of the game. Onboarding is often done through tutorials or through gameplay.

Pacing - The rhythm or speed of gameplay, balancing moments of tension, action, exploration, and rest (see also 'balance' and 'difficulty curve')

Pixel Art - The squares of light on a screen are called pixels. Old games, such as original Famicom (Nintendo) or Super Famicom games, used a limited number of pixels to make characters and objects in a game. Today, the style of game art that looks like older games is called pixel art.

Sprite - A sprite is any 2D object made of pixels or pixel art. Pixel art often has a background image, with sprites placed over the background. Player characters are often sprites in pixel art games.

Player Agency - The degree to which players can make meaningful choices that affect their experience or outcomes.

Progression - The system by which players gain new abilities, content, power, or knowledge over time (see also 'difficulty curve' and 'balance').

Replayability - The extent to which a game remains enjoyable and engaging across multiple playthroughs. Some games are designed to be replayable. Other games are designed to be played one time over a long period.

Reward System - The mechanisms that motivate players by providing incentives such as points, loot, achievements, or story advancement.

User Experience (UX) - The overall ease, clarity, accessibility, and satisfaction of playing the game.

User Interface (UI) - The visual elements through which players receive information and interact with game systems (see also 'gameplay').